

4.7 Addressing Compatibility Issues

Compatibility has long been a major concern for Windows. Microsoft has played a balancing act between providing compatibility for a wide range of hardware and software on the one hand, and making the OS stable and efficient on the other. Many users expect to be able to run their ancient DOS or Windows programs and outdated peripherals on the latest version of Windows.

Microsoft's attempt at building a system with a balance of compatibility and stability has been realised in Windows XP, which is built on the NT/2000 kernel. No matter how much work is done in achieving better compatibility, the problem of outdated hardware and software will always loom over the OS. It is therefore important to use new, supported hardware and software as far as possible. Microsoft has published a catalogue of hardware and software compatible with your OS at www.microsoft.com/whdc/hcl/default.msp.

Windows XP's Program Compatibility Mode is a tool designed to fool an application into thinking that it's running under an older version of Windows. Using Compatibility Mode, you can select whether to run a program in Windows 95, 98/Me, NT 4 or 2000 mode. You can also set screen resolution and maximum colour display, and disable visual themes. The Program Compatibility Wizard lets you test each setting in turn to see if it works. The Program Compatibility Wizard is accessible from Start > All Programs > Accessories > Program Compatibility.